SOURCE: MEPC.268(68).pdf
1.33 The area therefore demonstrates the characteristics of an isolated, effectively self-sustaining ecological unit, as evidenced by the high proportion of endemism both within the region, and between individual reef communities.

Fragility

1.34 Although the Coral Sea contains a number of critical shallow reef and terrestrial habitats, these represent less than 1% of the total area. Their small size, isolation from each other and high exposure to cyclones and storms make them more vulnerable to catastrophic impacts of natural disturbances than the contiguous reef systems of the GBR. These precarious conditions increase the area's ecological fragility and the risk of local extinctions. A high proportion of pelagic and deep-water species are particularly vulnerable to anthropogenic impacts.

1.35 While the isolation of the area's ecosystems has ensured a great deal of diversity and endemicity between communities and populations, it also means these systems can be particularly fragile and susceptible to external factors with potentially catastrophic, long-term cascade effects.

1.36 The area's deep-sea organisms are generally slow growing, long-lived,

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SOURCE: MEPC.268(68).pdf
particularly fragile and susceptible to external factors with potentially catastrophic, long-term cascade effects.

1.36 The area's deep-sea organisms are generally slow growing, long-lived, late-reproducing species with few offspring, and as a result can take a significant amount of time to rebuild populations. The cold coral reef systems take thousands of years to develop even in areas with stable conditions. They are fragile and extremely susceptible to damage as recovery rates are immensely slow.

https://edocs.imo.org/Final Documents/English/MEPC 68-21-ADD.1 (E).doc
Bio-geographic importance

1.37 A number of biologically important areas are located within, or intersect with the area:

.1 Seasonal migration routes and feeding sites for cetaceans including the humpback whale occur throughout the region. The humpback whale is also known to breed and calve in the area.

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.1 Seasonal migration routes and feeding sites for cetaceans including the

humpback whale occur throughout the region. The humpback whale is also known to breed and calve in the area.

.2 Migration routes and foraging and feeding sites for 13 species of seabird listed under the EPBC Act as threatened, endangered and/or migratory are located in the area.

.3 The green turtle breeds in the area, with the Coringa-Herald-Lihou area particularly important for nesting and inter-nesting activities.

.4 In spring and summer, whale sharks aggregate to feed around Bougainville Reef and white sharks use the south west Coral Sea, adjacent to the Swain Reefs, as they move between nursery areas and for opportunistic feeding.

.5 The minimal impacts on the area and its relative lack of disturbance mean that its various ecosystems provide a representation of what the geographic distribution of organisms would naturally resemble in comparable, but more highly impacted marine ecosystems around the world.

2 Social, cultural and economic criteria

Social or economic dependency

2.1 Commercial fisheries have a relatively small presence in the south west Coral Sea

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SOURCE: MEPC.268(68).pdf
highly impacted marine ecosystems around the world.

2 Social, cultural and economic criteria

Social or economic dependency

2.1 Commercial fisheries have a relatively small presence in the south west Coral Sea compared to other marine regions around Australia. Commonwealth and Queensland state managed fisheries occur in the area, including line, hand collection, trawl, purse seine, trap and net fisheries.

2.2 Almost all tourism activities that occur in the south west Coral Sea are nature-based and reliant on an intact Coral Sea ecosystem. They include charter fishing, snorkelling, scuba diving, whale watching and cruising.

2.3 Known scuba diving and snorkelling hotspots in the Coral Sea region include the Osprey and Shark Reefs, for their significant populations of shark. These activities also occur in the Coringa Islets, Herald Cays and at Lihou Reef, although the extreme isolation of these locations means that they are not often visited. They also take place off other islands and shallow water seafloor features in the Coral Sea region, albeit on a limited basis.

2.4 Scuba diving and snorkelling are predominantly eco-tourism or heritage-based

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SOURCE: MEPC.268(68).pdf
shallow water seafloor features in the Coral Sea region, albeit on a limited basis.

2.4 Scuba diving and snorkelling are predominantly eco-tourism or heritage-based tourism activities with participants preferring locations that offer near-pristine marine environments or dive wrecks of interest. Some commercial and educational organizations offer science-based tourism opportunities where divers and snorkelers participate in experiments or surveys. Cruise ships also frequent the region, some regularly visiting Willis Island.

RESOLUTION MEPC.268(68)
(adopted on 15 May 2015)
DESIGNATION OF THE SOUTH-WEST CORAL SEA AS AN EXTENSION OF THE GREAT BARRIER REEF AND TORRES STRAIT PARTICULARLY SENSITIVE SEA AREAMEPC 68/21/Add.1
Annex 14, page 10

https://edocs.imo.org/Final Documents/English/MEPC 68-21-ADD.1 (E).doc
Cultural heritage

2.5 Like the GBR and Torres Strait, the Coral Sea is also of indigenous cultural and social significance to island and coastal communities. Many Aboriginal and Torres Strait island people undertake traditional use of marine resource activities to provide traditional

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SOURCE: MEPC.268(68).pdf
social significance to island and coastal communities. Many Aboriginal and Torres Strait island people undertake traditional use of marine resource activities to provide traditional food, practice their living maritime culture and to educate younger generations about traditional and cultural rules and protocols.

2.6 The area contains a large number of historic shipwrecks, including the wrecks of the Cato and HMS Porpoise, which are located in protected zones established under Australia's Historic Shipwrecks Act 1976. The region was significant in the Battle of the Coral Sea during World War II.

3 Scientific and educational criteria

Research

3.1 Given the scale and location of the proposed extension area to the PSSA, large-scale oceanographic features are well known and documented. However, there is a lack of knowledge of finer-scale hydrodynamics linking habitats within the Coral Sea. Further, the potential impacts of climate change on the Coral Sea are yet to be understood.

3.2 In spite of the relatively few detailed studies on the area, it remains one of high scientific interest. The remote location of the area, and its reputation as one of the most

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SOURCE: MEPC.268(68).pdf
3.2 In spite of the relatively few detailed studies on the area, it remains one of high scientific interest. The remote location of the area, and its reputation as one of the most distinctive and undisturbed natural systems in the world, offers researchers a rare opportunity to study a biota over an area of significant scale that has not been markedly

impacted by fishing and which is likely to remain undisturbed.

3.3 Domestic and international research institutions are actively undertaking research in the area. In addition to research institutions, tourist operators and volunteer organisations maintain active monitoring programs.

3.4 The occupied meteorological facility on Willis Island has been providing data to Bureau of Meteorology scientists and others since 1921. Automatic weather stations are located on Bougainville Reef, Cato Island, Flinders Reef (Flinders Coral Cay), Frederick Reef, Holmes Reef, Lihou Reef (Turtle Islet), Marion Reef and Moore Reef. Observations from Willis Island and the automatic weather stations are important for climate analysis and numerical weather prediction models, for fine-tuning forecasts and warnings, and are

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SOURCE: MEPC.268(68).pdf
from Willis Island and the automatic weather stations are important for climate analysis and numerical weather prediction models, for fine-tuning forecasts and warnings, and are particularly important for early warning of tropical cyclones.

Baseline for monitoring studies

3.5 The extension area to the PSSA is remote and considered a relatively undisturbed